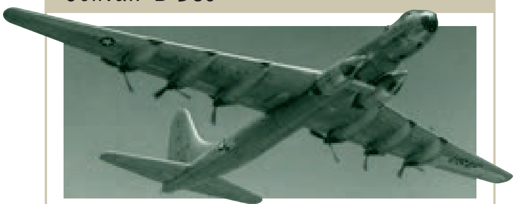
Convair B-36J



Ordered in 1941, when it seemed the US might have to attack Germany and Japan from its own territory, development of the B-36 was slowed down or speeded up depending on how the war was going. In 1945, it gained a new lease of life as its 10,000 mile (16,090km) range was capable of taking a nuclear attack to the United States' new enemy, the Soviet Union.

ENGINE 6 x 3,800hp P&W R-4360-53 Wasp Major air-cooled radial

WINGSPAN 230ft (70.2m) **LENGTH** 161ft 1in (49.4m)

TOP SPEED 411mph (661kph) **CREW** 15

ARMAMENT 16 x 20mm cannon in eight remote-controlled turrets; 72,000lb (32,710kg) bombload

Convair B-58 Hustler

The United States began development of this supersonic nuclear bomber in 1946. The weapon and much of the fuel were carried in the under-fuselage pod, which would be dropped on the target, making the aircraft faster and more fuel-efficient on the return journey. The project was on the limit of available technology and, after many delays and several near-cancellations, only entered service in 1961. By then, antiaircraft missiles had improved so much that the Hustler was vulnerable, and all aircraft were phased out in 1970.

ENGINE 4 x 15,000lbst (6,815kgp) thrust General Electric J79-GE-5B turbojet with afterburner

WINGSPAN 56ft 10in (17.3m) **LENGTH** 96ft 9in (29.5m)

TOP SPEED 1,319mph (2,122kph) (Mach 2) **CREW** 3

ARMAMENT 1 x 20mm M-61 rotary cannon in tail; nuclear bomb and fuel carried in large underfuselage pod

Myasishchev M-4 (Mya-4) "Bison"

The Soviet equivalent of the B-52 and entering service at about the same time, this strategic bomber was hardly known in the West for some years. Given the name "Bison" by NATO, its effectiveness, like that of the B-52, was eroded by improvements in fighter and missile defenses. However, it was not developed like the American aircraft into a tactical conventional bomber.

ENGINE 4 x 19,180lb (8,700kg) thrust Mikulin AM-3D turbojets

WINGSPAN 165ft 7in (50.5m) **LENGTH** 154ft 10in (47.2m)

TOP SPEED 620mph (998kph) **CREW** 8

ARMAMENT 7 x 23mm NR-23 cannon in two remote-controlled and one manned turrets and in nose; 33,000lb (15,000kg) bombload

Tupolev Tu-16 "Badger"

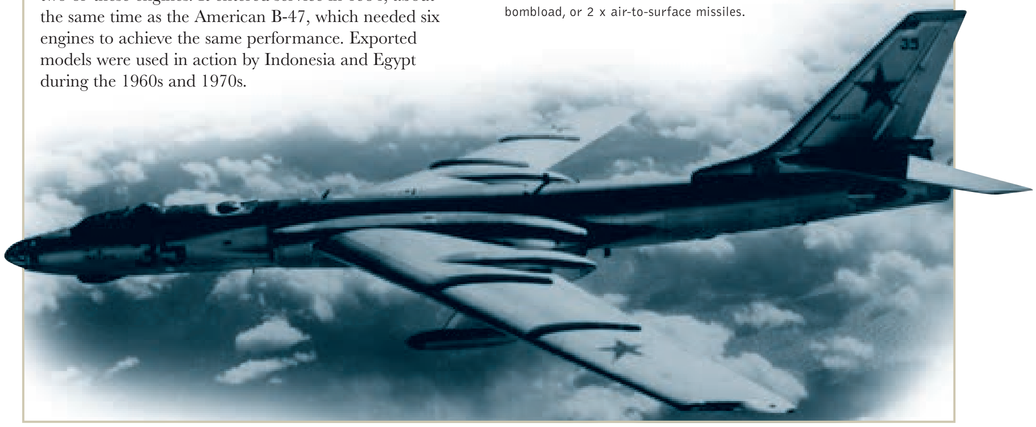
The Soviet Union's dependence on Rolls-Royce derived jet engines was ended by the development of the hugely powerful Mikulin AM-3. The Tu-16, known in the West as "Badger," was a long-range medium bomber using two of these engines. It entered service in 1954, about the same time as the American B-47, which needed six engines to achieve the same performance. Exported models were used in action by Indonesia and Egypt during the 1960s and 1970s.

ENGINE 2 x 20,945lb (9,500kg) thrust Mikulin AM-3M 301 turbojet

WINGSPAN 108ft (32.9m) **LENGTH** 118ft 11in (36.3m)

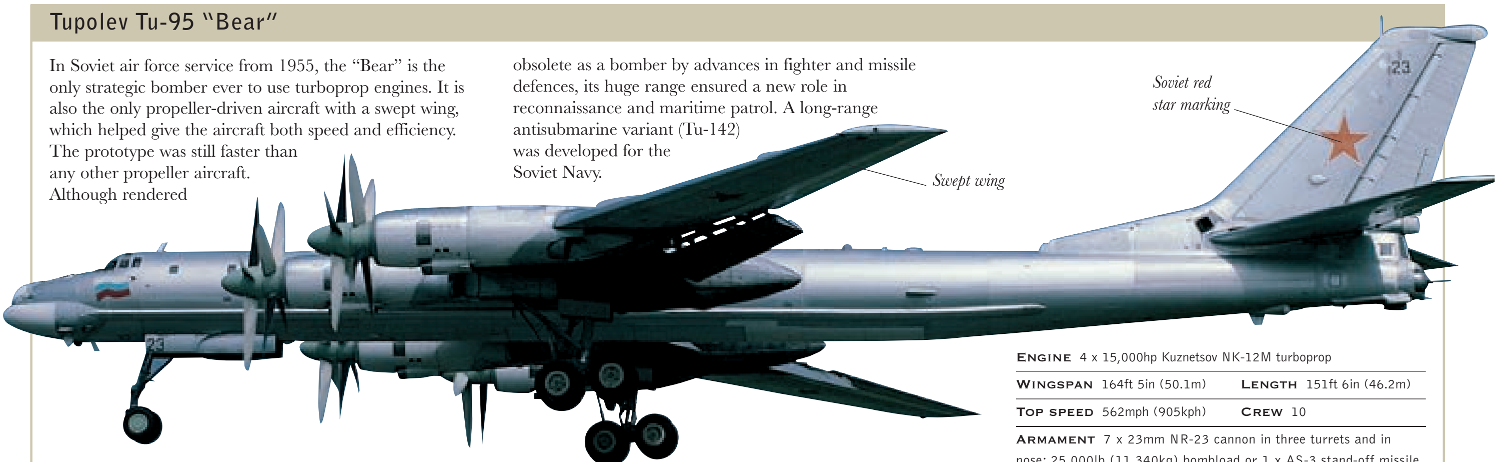
TOP SPEED 616mph (992kph) **CREW** 6

ARMAMENT 7 x 23mm NR-23 cannon; 13,000lb (6,000kg) bombload, or 2 x air-to-surface missiles.



Tupolev Tu-95 "Bear"

In Soviet air force service from 1955, the "Bear" is the only strategic bomber ever to use turboprop engines. It is also the only propeller-driven aircraft with a swept wing, which helped give the aircraft both speed and efficiency. The prototype was still faster than any other propeller aircraft. Although rendered obsolete as a bomber by advances in fighter and missile defences, its huge range ensured a new role in reconnaissance and maritime patrol. A long-range antisubmarine variant (Tu-142) was developed for the Soviet Navy.



ENGINE 4 x 15,000hp Kuznetsov NK-12M turboprop

WINGSPAN 164ft 5in (50.1m) **LENGTH** 151ft 6in (46.2m)

TOP SPEED 562mph (905kph) **CREW** 10

ARMAMENT 7 x 23mm NR-23 cannon in three turrets and in nose; 25,000lb (11,340kg) bombload or 1 x AS-3 stand-off missile